

THEATERS



People have enjoyed going to the theater to watch plays for thousands of years—the first theaters were built by the Greeks about 2,500 years ago.

Stone seats were carved into the hillside. The actors did not need microphones, because sound carried right up to the back row. Until the 17th century, most plays were staged out in the open. But by the 1650s, bare stages had been replaced by elaborate sets that had to be kept inside, so indoor theaters became common. Lights transformed theaters, too. Realistic acting began with the invention of the spotlight—for the first time, players' expressions could be seen.



It's a miracle

In the Middle Ages, actors from each town performed Bible stories. These were called miracle plays and were about the battle between Good and Evil.



Ancient art

Noh is an old, traditional type of Japanese theater. Religious stories and ancient myths are performed on a stage that has very little scenery. The plays, some of which are more than 500 years old, can go on for as long as six hours!



The upper gallery was about 25 feet (8 meters) above the ground.

Stage door

The Globe Theatre was first built in 1599.



More than 2,000 people could crowd in to watch a play. Only a few could afford to sit in these galleries.